

Mining Expert Calls

#3 China Economics: Policy-driven pick up in investment expected from Sept

Equities

Global

Basic Materials

We hosted UBS's Yu Song in Part #3 of our China Expert Call series

UBS Chief China Economist, Yu Song, notes China's growth was materially weaker than expected in 2Q at 4.3% due to policy tightening after 1Q GDP surprised to the upside; the govt signalled its intention to loosen policy at the July Politbureau meeting (to ensure it is able to achieve the 4.5-5.0% GDP growth target for 2026) but the measures have been slow to implement with data only starting to pick up in Sept. Yu expects sequential improvement in GDP in Sept/4Q with local govt encouraged to spend current budgets and accelerate projects in the 15th 5Yr Plan to ensure the low end of the growth target is achieved ([note](#)).

We note commodity demand indicators for China have also been soft in Apr-Jul, with broad-based weakness across industrial production, investment & property; investment activity is expected to pick up in the rest of the year with infrastructure the key lever to offset weakness in property and consumption. On commodity demand, we note there is a continued structural shift away from traditional end use sectors (i.e. steel in construction and property), towards 'new' infrastructure and energy transition-related investment (i.e. copper and aluminium) where there is more focused policy support.

- Policy response vs restriction:** After the strong growth in 1Q, the govt tightened policy which resulted in more risk aversion in the public sector and closer regulatory scrutiny in the private sector; this slowed the pace of overall investment and consumption (including govt consumption) in 2Q, with credit growth/bond issuance also slowing. In Yu's view, the govt is determined to achieve or beat the low end of the 4.5-5.0% target GDP growth for 2026. The policymakers' tones have changed with the July Politburo meeting, with local govt encouraged to step up investment in 3Q and utilise more of the fiscal funds (albeit the implementation only started from late August). **Why hasn't the policy response been more urgent?** Our China Economist believes that 1) strong growth in nominal variables, 2) lack of obvious near-term deflation threats, 3) solid fiscal revenue, 4) modest downward pressure in the A-share/equity market, 5) relatively stable geopolitical relationships, and 6) success in the development of new technologies including AI, have reduced the need for more aggressive policies ([note](#)). Overall, as fiscal spending had been running well behind schedule ([note](#)), we expect incremental fiscal expansion rather than monetary loosening.
- Consumption vs investment:** **Consumption** & retail sales remain in sequential contraction in August, however Yu believes that incremental policy support will move away from household consumption through social welfare/consumer good subsidies (as was the case in the prior 2 years, with diminishing returns and crowding out effects on other types of consumption). Instead, faster deployment of fiscal funds should support FAI & manufacturing **investment** in 2H. Headline FAI remains in ~10% y/y contraction in August, though we note FAI data quality is particularly low and likely reflect statistical issues as well as underlying investment weakness. There is scope for investment to reaccelerate with the govt calling 3Q a "window" period to build and invest. Yu sees opportunities in both the major projects under the 15th Five-Year Plan, and in the '6 networks' sectors (i.e. energy, electricity grids, logistics, and other systems with focus on AI and national security) ([note](#)). However, we expect more of the policy support and focus to shift towards AI-related areas and away from commodities-intensive traditional construction activities; investment in intellectual-property, an intangible component of FAI, rose 9.1% y/y in Jan-Jul and accounted for 15% of total FAI.

Myles Allsop

Analyst
 myles.allsop@ubs.com
 +44-20-7568 1693

Yu Song

Economist
 S1460526010002
 yu-zs.song@ubs.com
 +86-10-5832 8508

Daniel Major

Analyst
 daniel.major@ubs.com
 +44-20-7568 3472

Amy Yi Li

Analyst
 amy-yi.li@ubs.com
 +44-20-7568 2064

George Eadie

Analyst
 george.eadie@ubs.com
 +1-646-996 4596

Andrew Jones

Analyst
 andrew-i.jones@ubs.com
 +44-20-7901 6545

Sharon Ding

Analyst
 sharon.ding@ubs.com
 +852-2971 6284

Ethan Hong

Associate Analyst
 ethan.hong@ubs.com
 +1-212-649 8258

- **Property:** Property activities remain weak in August (with sales -15% y/y and starts -31% y/y); following our recent call with our China Property analyst ([note](#)) new property starts/completion could likely decline more meaningfully over the next two years following the shift away from the pre-sale system. Yu notes that policy easing momentum has waned for the sector although there are more supportive measures in the policymakers' toolbox (e.g. reducing downpayment ratio/ mortgage ratios or relaxing the Hukou system), with growth in export & 'new economy' sectors offsets property market weakness.

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